

Is This Safe? Sorting Game

Category	Sorting game - Critical thinking - Table engagement
Skill level	Beginner to run, Intermediate to discuss. Anyone can run it with the printed cards and the Volunteer Answer Key. Expect food-safety questions - lean on the key, and refer tricky ones to a Master Food Preserver. No technology needed for the printed version.
Audience	Best for Teens and Adults; older kids with a helper. Scenarios describe real home situations and some include numbers or terms.
Setup time	5-10 minutes

DESCRIPTION

Players read a realistic home food-preservation scenario and decide: is it SAFE, NOT SAFE, or IT DEPENDS? They place the card (or tap on the tablet) under the matching answer, then flip it for the answer and a plain-language explanation. The "IT DEPENDS" cards spark the best conversations - safety often hinges on one missing detail (the tested recipe, acidity, processing time, altitude, or equipment). 60 cards across 8 food-preservation topics.

MATERIALS NEEDED

Digital version (tablet)

- A tablet, charged, turned sideways (landscape).
- Open the game: sign in to the MFP Volunteer Resource Hub, tap "Toolkit," then "Play digital sort" on the Is This Safe? card. (You can filter by topic with the dropdown.)

Printed version (no technology needed)

- The scenario cards printed double-sided: "cards-front.pdf" (the scenario) on the front and "cards-back.pdf" (the answer + explanation) on the back.
- The three sorting signs from "sorting-labels.pdf": SAFE, NOT SAFE, and IT DEPENDS - placed across the table.
- The "Volunteer Answer Key" (volunteer-key.pdf) for the full answer, the reason, and likely follow-up questions.

Both versions

- Prizes (see the "Prize & Reward Ideas" guide), table, tablecloth, and MFP / OSU Extension signage.
- This run sheet on the table for quick reference.

SETUP

1. Decide digital, printed, or both (both is great - printed cards back up the tablet).
2. Printed: print the scenario cards double-sided (flip on the SHORT edge so the answer lines up on the back), then cut them apart. Print the three sorting signs and set them out left-to-right: SAFE, NOT SAFE, IT DEPENDS. Print the Volunteer Answer Key and keep it next to you.
3. Digital: charge the tablet, open the sort game, and try one card to confirm it works.
4. Lay out prizes and put the Answer Key and this run sheet where you can glance at them.

ACTIVITY DIRECTIONS

Running the DIGITAL game

1. Invite the visitor to read the scenario on the screen.
2. Ask them: SAFE, NOT SAFE, or IT DEPENDS? Have them tap their choice (the three big buttons).

3. The correct answer highlights and the explanation appears. Read it together.
4. Talk about it - especially for "IT DEPENDS," point out what the safety depends on. Give a prize.
5. Tap "Next card" for the next visitor. Use the topic dropdown if they want a specific topic.

Running the PRINTED game

1. Hand the visitor a scenario card (face up).
2. Ask them to place it under one of the three signs: SAFE, NOT SAFE, or IT DEPENDS.
3. Flip the card over for the answer and explanation. If they ask "why," use the Volunteer Answer Key.
4. Celebrate the conversation and give a prize. Return the card to the deck.

VOLUNTEER NOTES

- Keep the Volunteer Answer Key (printed, or the explanation on the tablet) next to you - it has the full answer and the "why" for every card, plus likely follow-up questions and answers.
- "IT DEPENDS" is the point, not a trick. The goal is the conversation about what safety hinges on (a tested recipe, acidity, time, altitude, equipment). It is the most valuable card type.
- Accuracy matters: this is food-safety content. Read the answer and explanation as written and do not improvise. Refer harder questions to a Master Food Preserver.
- Best for teens and adults. For younger kids, help them read and keep it light and fun.
- No tablet, or not comfortable with it? Use the printed cards and signs - the game plays exactly the same.
- Simple tablet help: the visitor taps one of the three big buttons. If the screen sleeps, tap to wake it. If it sticks, close and reopen the app from the home screen. It works without internet once open. Keep it charged.
- Restock prizes and sanitize hands and surfaces as needed.